

"Had I not been a singer, I would have loved to spend my entire life in a garage fine-tuning a Fiat or a Maruti."

SONG AND TRANCE

His search for inspiration is matched by a dogged determination to hone his talent and allow *gayaki* to be heard above the instantly gratifying clamour

■ By Kamaljeet Kaur Bajwa

Bhimsen Joshi is the most prominent Hindustani vocalist living today. As the best known of the many great disciples of Savai Gandharva, he has made Dharwad (in north Karnataka) home to Hindustani music. Along with Mallikarjun Mansur, Gangubai Hangal, Kumar Gandharva and Basav Rao Rajguru, he has ushered music into its golden age.

Joshi was born into a Brahmin family of Gadag in Karnataka. As a child he was passionate about music, to the chagrin of his father who wanted him to become a doctor or an engineer. He left home in search of a guru at the age of 11. His search took him to Kundgol, to Savai Gandharva, a disciple of Abdul Karim Khan, the founder of the Kirana Gharana. But



Q: When did he first perform on stage?

A: When he was 19

Q: Which famous music festival did he institute?

A: Savai Gandharva Sangheet Mahotsav

Q: Which book, written by his father Gururaj, chronicles the life story of his illustrious son?

A: *Naad-Putra*, in Kannada

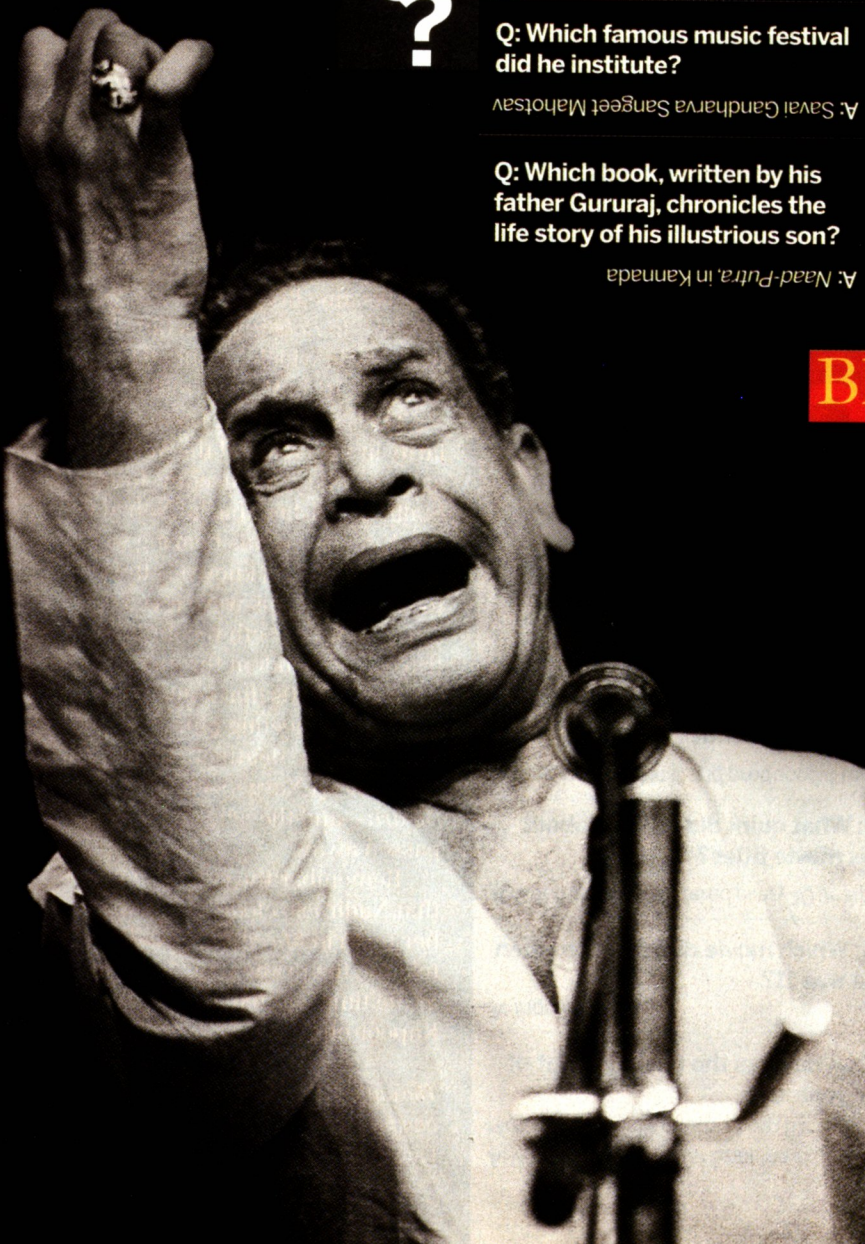
Bhimsen Joshi

Vocalist 1922

the guru rejected him, saying his voice was not good enough, taking him on only after seeing his determination and upon the recommendation of another student, Hangal.

From then on, Joshi absorbed raga after raga, imbibing the best of the gharana. He also learnt other styles of music, quickly becoming one of the most-sought-after performers, especially after the untimely death of Ustad Bade Ghulam Ali Khan in 1968 and Ustad Amir Khan in 1974. A versatile singer, Joshi's lilting thumris, bhajans in Hindi and Marathi and his abhangs are instances in point. A divine miracle, his tremendous accomplishments are proof of his musical genius.

The author is a voice instructor at the University of Alberta, Canada



ANAND PRASAD